with an exclusive executive director, while the majority of the countries are grouped into multi-country constituencies. India, for example, is the lead country in a constituency that also includes Bangladesh, Bhutan and Sri Lanka.

The main official event for the congregated finance ministers and central bank governors is the meeting of the IMFC which deliberates on the principal policy issues facing the IMF, held over half a day in a large, harshly lit conference hall in the IMF headquarters. Each executive director constituency is allowed a delegation of ten people at the meeting. While the delegation leaders occupy the front-row sofa seats, the rest of the delegation is seated in the rows behind. Together with the IMF staff, there are typically around 350 people in the meeting hall.

The IMFC is chaired by the finance minister or the central bank governor from one of the member countries, elected typically for a three-year term. During my tenure as governor, Youssef Boutros Ghali, the finance minister of Egypt, was the chairman till he resigned in 2011 following the defeat of his party in the elections in Egypt. He was succeeded by Tharman Shanmugaratnam, the finance minister of Singapore. Tharman, who has since been elevated as the deputy prime minister of Singapore, is intelligent, suave and articulate. I was always impressed by the way he steered the discussions, and especially for the special effort he made to bring emerging-market perspectives on to the issues, and for the maturity and skill he showed in coalescing a consensus on what were very divisive issues.

The format of the IMFC meeting has changed over time. Earlier, the meetings used to be quite staid, with the leader of each delegation reading out a prepared statement, with not much discussion or engagement with one another. That format has since yielded to a new pattern. The statements are now taken as read and are recorded. Under the new format, the meeting starts with a presentation by the chief economist of the IMF on the global economic outlook and by its financial counsellor on the global financial conditions. This is followed by a briefing by the IMF’s managing director on policy issues that need to be addressed by the IMF, such as global growth prospects, exchange rate movements and financial conditions.